Singapore Mahjong: a practical winning plan

Original study companion • Prepared 7 October 2026. Mahjong includes chance: stronger decisions improve your results over many games, but do not guarantee a win. This is a practical foundation, not an exhaustive rulebook.

Read the downloaded files in this order

01 - Singaporean Rules and Scoring: a two-page reference from Mahjong Picture Guide. Use it to recognise scoring patterns. Treat its values as one rules profile, not a universal standard.

02 - SPGG Mahjong Rules 2024: seven pages of local club rules and procedures. Useful for table discipline and disputes; these are SPGG rules, not rules binding every Singapore table.

03 - Riichi Book 1: Daina Chiba's freely released Japanese-mahjong strategy book. Begin with the basic tile-efficiency material (chapters 3-4). Connected shapes and wait counting transfer well. Riichi declarations, dora, furiten, Japanese scoring and Japanese push/fold thresholds do not transfer directly.

Agree the rules before deciding your strategy

Write down minimum tai, maximum tai, payment schedule for discard wins and self-draw, and who pays. Confirm flower/animal scoring and immediate bonuses; Ping Hu requirements and its bonus-tile treatment; permitted special hands; kong and robbing-kong rules; passed-win restrictions; bao responsibility; and dealer continuation. Small rule differences can change the best decision.

The hand you are trying to build

A normal winning hand has four sets and one pair. A set is a same-suit sequence of three consecutive ranks, or three identical tiles; a kong is four identical tiles with a replacement draw. Bonus tiles are exposed and replaced rather than used in these sets. Special hands need separate confirmation.

For an ordinary hand, Chi claims a sequence from the player immediately before you; Pong claims a triplet from any player. Know call priority and timing at your table. A complete shape still needs to meet your table's minimum tai.

Build faster hands with more options

1. Give every tile a job

Divide the hand into four set candidates and a pair candidate. Completed sets, connected pairs of suited tiles and pairs of identical tiles are useful building blocks. Identify surplus or isolated tiles, but examine overlapping shapes before breaking anything. Five blocks is a planning aid, not a command to keep the first five shapes you see.

2. Compare the actual useful tiles

In one suit, 4-5 completes with 3 or 6: eight copies in total before accounting for visible tiles. 4-6 needs 5, and 1-2 needs 3: four copies each. Two-sided shapes usually offer more ways forward. However, keep a scoring route and consider the whole hand, not just one block.

Example: you hold 4-5 Bamboo. One 3 Bamboo and two 6 Bamboo are visible outside your hand, so at most five completing copies remain unseen. Those five may be in opponents' hands rather than the wall. Count each physical tile once; a called discard now in a meld is not two visible tiles.

3. Discard with a reason

Early in a normal sequence-oriented hand, isolated non-scoring honours and isolated terminals are often expendable. Middle suited tiles can join more sequences. Exceptions matter: a useful honour pair can supply tai; a terminal can complete an existing edge shape; an otherwise weak tile may be your only pair or a defensive reserve.

4. Use calls when they improve the whole plan

Before Chi or Pong, picture the remaining tiles and your next discard. Does the call move you closer to a legal win? Does it destroy your pair, remove useful alternative shapes, or force a risky discard? Exposing tiles also reveals your direction. Calling merely because you can is not a strategy.

5. Get enough tai, then weigh speed against value

Identify a realistic scoring route early. If bonus tiles already meet the minimum under your rules, you may be able to prioritise a fast ordinary hand. If you lack tai, preserve a plausible scoring route instead of racing toward an ineligible hand. Pursue a flush or all-triplet hand when the starting tiles support it; repeatedly discarding useful tiles to force a big hand often costs speed.

Once you reach the payout cap, extra tai may add no hand-win value, although separate bonuses can still matter. Compare a faster modest win with a slower valuable hand using your actual payment schedule.

Defend, practise and review

Read evidence, not certainties

Track open melds, bonus tiles, missing suits and late changes in discard patterns. An opponent exposing several melds deserves attention, but meld count alone does not prove they are ready. A flush-looking hand raises concern about that suit and honours; it does not identify a particular winning tile.

Choose whether to push or fold each turn

Push more readily with a legal, valuable hand close to completion and several unseen winning tiles. Defend more readily with a slow hand, a poor wait, little value, or a conspicuous valuable threat. When folding, accept breaking your hand to reduce the chance of paying out. Reassess after every meaningful call or discard.

A tile an opponent discarded earlier is **not automatically safe** in Singapore mahjong: do not import Japanese furiten or permanent safe-tile assumptions. Their hand can change. Four visible copies of a tile prove no unseen copies remain, but nearby ranks may still complete a sequence. Visible information narrows possibilities; it rarely eliminates every risk.

Kong decisions need care

A kong can give a replacement draw or a bonus under some rules. It can also sacrifice flexible shapes, expose information, or create a robbing-kong opportunity. Check the exact kong type and table rules before judging the benefit. Do not kong reflexively.

A short practice routine

Before each discard: name your scoring route, count how close you are to completion, identify improving tiles, subtract visible copies, and inspect opponents' threats. When ready, list every winning tile and check that each produces a legal scoring hand.

After each session: review three difficult discards and two calls. Record the hand, visible tiles, intended tai and your reasoning. Judge the decision using information available at the time, not whether a lucky tile appeared later. Track missed legal wins, wasted calls and expensive discard losses as well as wins.

Online sources and continued study

Downloaded originals:
Mahjong Picture Guide: Singaporean reference PDF
SPGG: Mahjong Rules and Regulations, January 2024
Daina Chiba: Author's Riichi Book I download page.

Additional Singapore-specific reading: Wong Hong Wei's online guide, especially its rules-variation and strategy sections. This is an app author's rules profile and teaching resource; it states that independent instructor/club review remains pending. This companion provides original practical synthesis rather than reproducing that website.